

From Gates to Gradients

On making Axona a greater good · a companion to Axona: Synopsis and Implications (D. A. Smith, v0.1) · v0.1 · 2026-06-12

We shape our tools and thereafter our tools shape us.

John M. Culkin, on Marshall McLuhan, 1967

The false binary

The synopsis poses a choice between two dangers: assembly held permanently at the discretion of a few intermediaries, or a cascade that no power can stop. Presented as the only options, the second looks like the lesser evil and the matter is closed. But the binary is false, and the space worth working in is the middle the synopsis declines to enter — out of an honest, faintly self-flattering attachment to having no platform in the middle at all.¹

Two distinctions open that middle.

Capability versus defaults. The dual-use property cannot be engineered away, and the synopsis is right that uncensorable and ungovernable are a single fact. But *what the wire can carry* is a different question from what is cheap, what happens by default, and where friction sits. Almost all of the available good lives in the second question — and none of it requires a chokepoint.

Governance versus control. Platforms fused two things the language treats as one: the *functions* of governance — friction, identity-weight, filtering, context on what is false — and *control*, the monopoly chokepoint that performed them. The synopsis's grievance is with the fusion, not the functions. Axona's opportunity is to keep the functions and discard the fusion.

From these follows the whole program, and its slogan: **replace gates with gradients**. A platform governs with gates — binary verdicts of in or out, up or down, kept or deleted, each a lever someone owns and can abuse. Axona cannot offer a gate without rebuilding the chokepoint that defines it. It can offer gradients: costs that scale, friction that rises with reach, filters that layer and fork. A gate is a wall with a keeper. A gradient is a slope with no one standing at the top.²

What costs nothing

Three changes ask the architecture to surrender none of its thesis. Their absence from the synopsis is its clearest gap, because the document *names* these levers and then declines to pull them.

1 · **MAKE IDENTITY COSTLY, NOT GATED.** The hinge of every other risk is that identity is free, and a free identity is a Sybil swarm waiting to happen: one operator minting ten thousand keypairs, cryptographically indistinguishable from ten thousand citizens, forging consensus at the price of compute.³ *Costly* and *permissioned* are different axes. A proof-of-work mint, a small stake or burn, or a non-custodial proof of personhood imposes a cost that no authority adjudicates. No one can deny you an identity; it

¹ The document is unusually candid about its own limits; this is a critique from inside its premises, not against them. It grants the central claim — that uncensorable and ungovernable are one fact — and asks what remains possible once that is granted.

² Markets made exactly this turn after the 2010 flash crash — but markets could install a gate, an exchange-level halt, because an exchange is a chokepoint. Axona has none to add, so it must do the harder thing and grade the slope itself.

³ This is why a sense of the crowd — reputation, what is trending, the feeling that many agree — is forgeable the moment identities are free. The synopsis

simply isn't free to run a thousand. This single change rebalances the defender–attacker asymmetry that haunts everything that follows.

2 · **MAKE AGENTS LEGIBLE AS AGENTS.** The qualitatively new fact is that publishers and subscribers are increasingly machines, acting at a tempo our institutions were never built to match. The danger is not their presence; it is their *indistinguishability* from civic actors. A protocol-level affordance — an agent identity class, signed provenance carried on the message — gates no one and slows nothing, yet it lets a person choose their exposure to machine-speed traffic knowingly.⁴

3 · **SCALE FRICTION TO REACH.** The one flash-crash lesson that transfers without a chokepoint: friction can track blast radius. A message to twelve neighbours should cost nothing; a message fanning out to a hundred thousand strangers can cost a little — a rate ceiling, a proof-of-work that grows with the subscriber count, a brief delay above some fan-out threshold. This is per-node default behaviour, not central throttling. No one is stopped. Runaway velocity is merely made to cost what runaway velocity is worth.⁵

What costs a layer

Two further goods leave the base layer untouched and sit above it, opt-in.

4 · **MAKE SUBSCRIPTION THE MODERATION SURFACE — AND MAKE IT PLURAL.** Axona dissolves three of the four classical moderation surfaces and keeps only the most local: what each node relays, and what each community chooses to subscribe to.

The four surfaces, and what becomes of each.

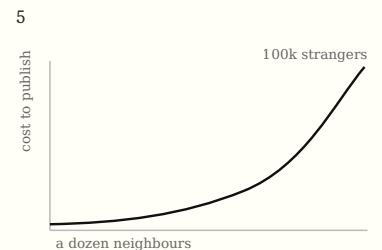
Surface	Platform lever	Fate on Axona
ACCESS	who may join	dissolved — a keypair and a tab
DISTRIBUTION	what is amplified	dissolved — no ranker, no throttle
RETENTION	what stays up	dissolved — retraction is best-effort
ATTRIBUTION	who said it	inverted — keys certain, identities unknown

Only subscription survives, and the reflex is to call it a human-scale defence against a machine-scale threat. As stated, it is. The repair is to let the defence run at machine scale too: composable, forkable, shareable filter sets — and your own agents on the defending side, your filter against their flood.⁶ The way to escape email's endgame is to make filter sets first-class, portable objects with zero switching cost — many competing curators, fork-on-disagreement — rather than one indispensable filterer. Subscription is the surface Axona keeps; the leverage is in making it powerful and plural instead of an afterthought.

5 · **GIVE RETRACTION TEETH WITHOUT GIVING IT DELETION.** Retraction cannot be guaranteed; any holder of the bytes keeps them, and no architecture changes that. But the *gap* between a retraction and the still-circulating bytes can be made visible: a signed retraction signal that rides the same mesh, so a message known to be retracted-by-author travels with that flag attached. It unsays nothing. It changes what a good-faith

lists “the cost of an identity” among the affordances it says govern a cascade, then leaves that cost at zero: the lever is named, not moved.

⁴ Human latency — sleep, doubt, the need to be persuaded — was never a bug. It was the system's accidental damping, the refractory period that let a cascade meet friction before it ran. Agents strip it out; legibility lets it be restored by choice.



Friction scaled to reach: near-free for local messages, rising with audience. A gradient, not a gate — and the refractory period agents lack, written into the protocol rather than rented from a platform.

⁶ This is the email lesson, half-learned. The openness of SMTP pushed spam-fighting to the edge; the edge then re-centralised into a few filtering operators. The trap is not edge filtering — it is *lock-in* at the edge. Avoid that specific fate and the surface holds.

node, filter, or agent does with it — converting retraction from a deletion, which is impossible, into attached context, which is cheap and honest.⁷

What cannot be bought

Two things must be said plainly, or this becomes advocacy rather than analysis.

None of it touches a determined adversary. Every measure above shapes the default path and raises the cost of casual or scaled abuse. A motivated, well-resourced actor — a state, a serious operator — can pay the identity cost, ignore the friction, strip the provenance, and route around any community's filters. This is not a defect to be patched; it is the literal content of *uncensorable*, seen from the dangerous side.⁸ The honest claim is not that this makes Axona safe. It is that it makes the benign path cheap and casual abuse expensive, and concedes the determined adversary as the unavoidable price of the civic good the synopsis is right to want. Anyone promising more is selling the chokepoint back under a new name.

You cannot steer what you refuse to measure. The synopsis's deepest admission is that it can instrument latency but not consequence — the thing it most needs to see travels on the same wire and is invisible to it. Every gradient above is a guess until that changes. So the highest-leverage move on this entire list is the least technical, and the one the synopsis states as a virtue rather than a deliverable: build the measurement. Not surveillance of content — that rebuilds the very panopticon the project exists to refuse — but aggregate, privacy-preserving telemetry on cascade *dynamics*: how fast topics spread, the ratio of agents to people in a propagation, how often a retraction loses its race against the bytes.⁹ Affordances can be tuned toward the good only by someone able to see whether they are working.

Governance without a governor

The program reduces to a single, uncomfortable recognition. Nearly every move here reintroduces — as a cost, a default, an opt-in layer — a function the platform once performed as a gate: friction, identity-weight, filtering, context on what is false. The platform was not wrong to perform those functions. It was wrong to perform them as an unaccountable monopoly. The greater-good version of Axona is therefore not a system with no governance. It is one where governance is *unbundled from control* — cheap to provide, impossible to monopolise, and forkable by anyone who disagrees.

Whether that is a stable equilibrium or merely a way-station back toward new intermediaries is the open question, and it is the same one the history of email keeps asking. The synopsis closes by insisting the thing is now a process, not a diagram. That is precisely why this is the moment the choices are still live: a process can still be shaped by the gradients built into it, before its habits harden into a topology.¹⁰ The wire is laid. What remains to be decided is not whether anyone sits in the middle — no one does, and no one will — but how steep the slopes are, and who is permitted to draw them.

⁷ On a substrate where deletion is a fiction, pretending to delete earns no one's trust. Honest, visible staleness does. The same logic carries corrections and disputes: annotations that ride alongside, never authorities that remove.

⁸ This concession is not a footnote to the program. It is the program's outer boundary, and naming it is the whole difference between a hedge and a hope.

⁹ "Keep studying the process we have set loose" is the right instinct, stated as an obligation one feels rather than one ships. Make it a deliverable with instruments, or the gradients are graded blind.

¹⁰ A slope with no one at the top can still be well-graded. That, and not a brake, is the whole of the available good — and it is more than the synopsis allows itself to hope for.